BOOKS

MAPPING CHINA'S MIGHT

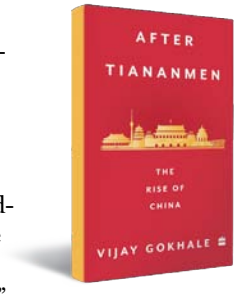
By Chandrashekhar Dasgupta

The two books under review offer important new perspectives on China's rise since 1989. In the two decades under Jiang Zemin and Hu Jintao, China achieved spectacular economic growth, while keeping a relatively modest international profile in accordance with Deng Xiaoping's injunction to "hide our capacities and bide our time". That period came to an end when Xi Jinping decided that the time was ripe for China to follow a "proactive" foreign policy, conducting itself as an assertive, and even aggressive, superpower.

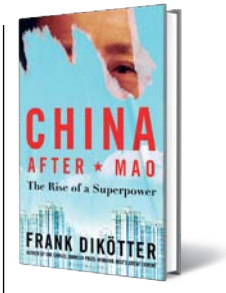
Gokhale, a former foreign secretary and ambassador to China, combines experience and scholarship with a rare gift for lucid exposition. Writing primarily for an Indian audience, he deftly sketches China's domestic politics, economic reforms and foreign policy since 1989, before proceeding to analyse shifts in India-China relations. This book is essential reading for anyone interested in understanding China's rise and its implications for India.

In December 1988, India and China agreed to normalise bilateral relations, without making this conditional on a prior settlement of the boundary question. They also agreed to maintain peace and tranquility in the border regions, pending a final settlement. In 1993, the two countries concluded a formal agreement to give effect to this understanding. In 2003, it was decided to appoint special representatives to explore the framework for a boundary settlement. Yet, as Gokhale notes, Chinese "backsliding" on the boundary question was visible by 2005.

What explains the lack of progress on the border issue and the more recent tensions along the Line of Actual Control (LAC)? In the course of his narrative, Gokhale points to contributory factors. China defines the LAC as the line that existed on November 7, 1959, while India understands it as the actual ground position prevailing at the time the agreement was concluded. Furthermore, Gokhale suggests, a partial explanation for the setback "might lie in the 1993 and 1996 agreements themselves. In the process of their implementation, both India and China realised the backwardness of their infrastructure in the border areas...China began modernising its infrastructure by the late 1990s and India followed suit...'Face offs' became more frequent". Finally, Gokhale underlines the implications of the widening "power asymmetry that developed after the Chinese economy took off".



AFTER TIANANMEN: THE RISE OF CHINA
by Vijay Gokhale
HARPERCOLLINS INDIA
₹399; 240 pages



CHINA AFTER MAO: THE RISE OF A SUPERPOWER
by Frank Dikötter
BLOOMSBURY PUBLISHING
₹699; 416 pages

The Hong Kong-based Dutch sinologist Frank Dikötter makes good use of some Chinese provincial and municipal archives that he was able to access, as well as the Li Rui diaries, to provide a captivating account of the factional struggles within the Chinese Communist Party from 1976 to the present day. He paints a picture of "bitter backstabbing and fighting for power among endlessly changing factions". Relying on the Li Rui diaries, he offers a vivid and detailed account of the policy debates within the Chinese Communist Party at the time of the Tiananmen incident.

Dikötter takes a bleak view of China's future prospects: "China resembles a tanker that looks impressively shipshape from a distance, with the captain and his lieutenants standing proudly on the bridge, while below deck sailors are desperately pumping water and plugging holes to keep the vessel afloat." Again, the "challenge lying ahead for the Communist Party was how to address an entire range of longstanding structural issues of its own making without giving up its monopoly over power and its control over the means of production. It seems very much like a dead end".

These forecasts appear to reflect Dikötter's belief that "there is no economic freedom without political freedom"—a thesis that is open to question in light of the economic achievements of Hitler's Germany or Mussolini's Italy. China today does, indeed, face several formidable challenges. In addition to the major imbalances associated with rapid growth over three decades, it confronts the new challenge of a sharp decline in growth rates. Since China has already narrowed the technology gap with developed countries, there is limited scope for further technological "leapfrogging". Moreover, it has an ageing population on account of its earlier 'one child' policy. Nevertheless, it would not be prudent to assume that China will fail to meet these challenges, given its past record. ■

The reviewer is a former ambassador to China